Yvonne Lee & Joy Pagdilao Informational Interview

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[00:00:03] Joy Pagdilao: Okay, good morning! Let me also just start off with my introduction, because I know I didn't really provide a lot of information on who I am. I know you're familiar with Jean, but yeah, my name is Joy, and I'm one of Jean's peers. I go by Joy, but my name is Samantha.

I have a Bachelors of Science in Business Psychology, and I'm in the MLIS program here at UCLA. My focus is towards Library Studies, and particularly I want to do, community archives and outreach and engagement-- more public-facing work, front end. And I particularly want to work with, like, underprivileged and underserved communities, like Latino and AAPI communities, since that's also, the group that I grew up with predominantly. And that's where part of, like, my motivation for, like, my studies came.

And that's just so that you know, like, what I'm familiar with. But yeah, thank you so much for being willing to do this, and yeah, like, we can go ahead and dive in. If you want, do you want to give, like, a background on your position? Yeah.

[00:01:25] Yvonne Lee: Yeah. Let's start there. I am so intrigued by Business Psychology. I'd be curious to hear more about that and the course itself.

So, my name is Yvonne Lee. My title is Director of Integrated Systems...We recently went through a rebranding last spring, so we were formerly the Huntington Library, Art Museum, and Botanical Garden. So that was quite a mouthful, and so part of the rebranding effort was to shorten it down to The Huntington.

[unclear] But, I'll be here for 5 years (in May), working in the Digital and Technology Division. We're a vast organization, numbers over 500 full-time and part-time employees.

So prior to working at Huntington, I was at the Los Angeles County Museum of Art, where I was the Head of Collections Information and Digital Assets which was a part of the collections group along with Registration, Art Preparation, and Collections Management. And prior to that, I was working for the Los Angeles County and Arts and Culture...[unclear]. So, I'm working in the arts program, and of course, UCLA, which I [unclear]...So, I've been working in the arts for a little over…wow 15 years perhaps? Working primarily...art galleries as well as…in a research context, [unclear] and…technology and data context and support.

[00:03:25] Joy Pagdilao: Awesome, okay. I did want to point out, the audio doesn't sound… as clear? Like, it kind of sounds like you have… An echo? You kind of sound robotic.

[00:03:41] Yvonne Lee: Oh, that's weird...[unclear] my audio sensitivity.

[00:04:05] Joy Pagdilao: Yeah. I think you said you're trying to mess with the sensitivity.

[00:04:10] Yvonne Lee: Yeah, how about that? Is that any different?

[00:04:12] Joy Pagdilao: That does sound better, yeah! When you were talking about… no, you're okay. When you were talking about your positions, I was able to make out the words and be able to understand the sentence, but it took a while for each of, like, the words to come out.

[00:04:28] Yvonne Lee: Oh.

[00:04:29] Joy Pagdilao: So I didn't hear, like, yeah, the beginning of, like those words.

[00:04:30] Yvonne Lee: Weird.

[00:04:32] Joy Pagdilao: But, yeah. Okay. And, yeah, I got a rundown from Jean on your positions at The Huntington. Really cool stuff! I've never heard of digital asset management, like I told you, I've never really done a lot of, like, back-end work, so your work sounds really intriguing to me. Like, really cool stuff. But yes, okay. What…do you… what do you think would be, like, best? Do you want to maybe talk about your background and, like, how you got…motivated and inspired to do, like, your type of work? And, like, do you want to start with maybe your schooling, and then work towards, like, your professional career, like, to this day, or-

[00:05:24] Yvonne Lee: Sure.

[00:05:25] Joy Pagdilao: Like, do you want- Okay.

[00:05:26] Yvonne Lee: So, hopefully the audio sounds okay right now. Okay, good.

[00:05:30] Joy Pagdilao: That actually sounds great.

[00:05:32] Yvonne Lee: Yeah, I don't know why, but it kept defaulting over to my camera.

[00:05:37] Joy Pagdilao: Oh!

[00:05:38] Yvonne Lee: So I'm not sure. But I'll just keep an eye on that if you just want to give me, like, a hand gesture to let me know that the audio… again, yeah, it just seems to sort of switch on and off, but, sure, let's see.

So I'm somebody who grew up going to museums as part of school trips, and remember a real sense of awe. I did not particularly feel a sense of belonging. I don't know that a lot of, you know, 8 to 10-year-olds really feel that strong sense, but maybe they do, you know, honestly. I can only sort of speak to my own experience. But I remember thinking that there was something really special about museums, and libraries and spaces like that. I did spend a lot of my time growing up in public libraries, in Los Angeles, so I felt very at home in libraries, like a secondary home, away from school, away from home. And yet, for whatever reason, that didn't necessarily extend to other cultural heritage and places of memory institutions like museums. That said, I love art. I have always engaged in some sort of practice of art, visual art, specifically, and so, I think…and growing up, I didn't have anyone in my family who were curators or people who worked in museums, and so… or libraries for that matter, and so, I wasn't aware that that was a possibility as far as a career was concerned. That said, when I went to undergraduate, I-

I should back up. So, in high school, we were lucky enough to have art history offered as some of the classes that you could take as, I think, a junior or a senior, and so I did. And I remember just being really enthralled with the mix of history, material sciences, Psychology, sociology, anthropology. And of course, visual arts, and so art history was something that was really a wonderful course in high school, and I was so excited that when I went to undergrad, that they had an incredibly strong art history program. So I actually went into undergrad undecided, thinking I would most likely be an English major. But found, and this just maybe more speaks to my lack of preparation when selecting undergraduate colleges, that they had an incredible undergraduate program. And so, I switched my major from English to Art History, and did that for 4 years, and at that point, I thought that where I could find myself the most of service, or perhaps able to find a job after graduation would be working in an art gallery, in a commercial art gallery. So this is what's generally referred to as the primary market, secondary market being, like, auction houses like Sotheby's, and Bonhams and such.

So, that's what I did for several years, was working in, primary market, working as a, art dealer, art gallerist in the Bay Area and down in Los Angeles. And, after a while, I think it was about 2008, is when, something really started to change for me, and the types of…clients that we saw, the types of collectors that I interacted with, didn't even have the…didn't even give the illusion of caring particularly about the art. At that point, art was decided to be the largest unregulated market in the world, worth billions, trillions, in fact, and so there were a lot of folks like hedge fund managers, and it's not unusual to see hedge fund managers in art galleries, however, they did not… these, new clients did not particularly have any interest in art, and would say things that, to me, were rather shocking and very detrimental to the career of a young artist, or an emerging artist. I should say, to say, you know, “I heard that this was something that would be a good investment, I'm not even gonna look at it. It's gonna sit in a warehouse in Switzerland for 5 years, and then I'm gonna flip it.”

And, I realized that I didn't want to be a part of that. During, my time in art galleries, one of my tasks was to maintain the, inventory database and, log in, transactions, interactions, details about the artwork, information about the artist, about other galleries, about sales, sales through secondary markets, as well through, so auction sales, and charting those. And I realized that that was an area that I really…enjoyed and found some competency in. Like, I was good with…data. I enjoyed working with data, certainly more so than the clients at the time.

And so, I started asking around and doing informational interviews. A very good friend of mine at that point, somebody that I had met through undergraduate, was a career librarian, was a career public librarian, and then an independent research library librarian. And…he had suggested looking into MLIS programs, and because I was in California at the time, at that time, there were only two, San Jose State, which was largely understood to be a residency program, and then UCLA. This is prior to USC and anyone else sort of getting, ALA accreditation, and knowing my personal preference for in-person, sort of tuition, I opted to apply for UCLA's MLIS program. And was accepted.

During this time, I started taking on different types of work as I moved away from working in an art gallery, and I found myself working, as a community archivist for a, graffiti project, called The Placa Project, by Steve Grody, and archiving his decades' worth of work, along with those of, other graffiti historians and archivists, and, organizing it, and arranging, and then describing, and then, making that accessible for others as well. And so, I had some

taste of what archival work could look like outside of the, framework of, sales, of markets, per se. And so… I joined the, Archival Studies cohort.

When I started at UCLA during that time, there was also an informatics- it wouldn't be a major, but… or it wouldn't be a minor, but, or a cohort, per se, but, I found myself really drawn to courses provided at UCLA in the MLIS, in the iSchool around databases. At that time, there weren't a lot of coding develop… developer classes, like, the idea was that if you're interested, you would maybe go to, computer sciences to take those classes. You wouldn't necessarily stay in the iSchool, and so,
Yvonne Lee: of the classes that were being offered through the iSchool, I tried to take as many informatics courses as possible. Chris Borgman's, data management courses were really key to sort of understanding the larger context of where data fits into a society, and how data is used and stored, and…budgeted? And how to sort of understand this work in a larger context, not just for a scientific research, but also for the humanities and then after graduation, I worked with, some consultant groups to provide data management for, again, arts and culture projects, and then, after being sort of a consultant for several years, that's when the Los Angeles County Department of Arts and Culture position came up. And thus sort of began, my arc into working in institutions, again, like museums and libraries.

[00:14:13] Joy Pagdilao: I'm just taking notes, so I'm finishing. Thank you. Back to GLAM (galleries, libraries, archives, and museums). Wow. That's some really cool stuff. You have… Such a cool history. I feel like I grew up- I also should say, I typically turn these interviews, even though they're, like, supposed to be for classes, I turn them into, like, a really more informational interview coffee chat. That's why I called it a chat. So, yeah, I…I grew up in, like, Central California, where… I don't know, do you know where Delano or Bakersfield is? Yeah, I grew up in Delano, so, I grew up with, like, a heavily Hispanic, Filipino community that's also…very underserved. And our library was open maybe, like, 3 or 4 times- days a week, and I loved going there because in the summer, when it hits, like, triple digits, there was always, like, an AC on, and there was also, like, a nice safe space, so…I loved it for that aspect, and I didn't really grow up with, like, any other kids who went to the library as well, so… I resonate with that. Like, finding this place that feels so special.
And you provided so much information with, like, such little time. Thank you so much. Like, I think that leads us into some great places for us to, like, pick apart and digest. Let me run through the questions, like really quickly, and then let me see…where we can go from there. Okay, I guess…Oh, I guess this is, like, a question where we can start off with. So, I'm looking particularly at the list of, like, bulleted questions under “Job Market Outlook/Labor Trends”. So…

I guess what I'm thinking about is…it sounds like you've kind of… been within the…industry of, like, digital asset management for a while. Would you consider, like, the work that you did under galleries and…Yeah, like…as, like, selling, like, would you consider that digital asset management? Because you were working, like, on, I guess, organization with, like, sales and, like, that aspect of it?

[00:17:05] Yvonne Lee: Yeah, I think that there are several competing definitions or understandings or contexts for digital asset management. So, in a library or museum context, it's usually, what are you doing with the images and media full life cycle of these particular, files, right? And the way that they, support business operations. Digital assets can also mean, from a government standpoint, NFTs, right? And so, for a while, digital asset management, roles were really about, managing, blockchain and crypto, and specifically, sort of, art.

So…going back to your earlier question, when I was working at a gallery, it wasn't so much digital asset management, and I would actually say that today my work has less to do with digital asset as a particular type, as it's sort of understood in a library museum context, and more with art. I mean, more with data, in general. And so, whether they are bits or bytes or blobs, in the case of image files, it has a lot more…of a general reach having to do with how do organizations work with the data that they have? How do they, refine the data or prioritize which data to pay attention to when making business decisions or, and everything that's associated with that, so in digital asset management, that also has to do with rights and usage, intellectual property, a lot of legal concerns, as well as donor management or artist relationships.

And so, to me, all of those fit under a broader umbrella about data management and less so about DAMs, specifically as a…role or, area. So, the…so, if I understand it in that way, instead of just narrowly sort of digital asset management systems in the library and museum context, then yes, I would say that the work that I did in the galleries very much had to do with understanding the role of data, organizationally.

[00:19:31] Joy Pagdilao: Thank you. That was more of a question on my end, just to, like, understand…I guess, like, the flow of, like, what your… what your work has looked like over time.

[00:19:42] Yvonne Lee: Yeah, I mean, another thing to that is that, when I started at the Huntington nearly 5 years ago, the role was very much geared towards implementing a digital asset management system. However, since then, it's grown wider, so the definition of my title, Integrated Systems, is any enterprise application or software that's utilized by two or more divisions here at The Huntington. So that includes our CRM, or Constituent Relationship Management Database. It includes some aspects of our ticketing database, which is how visitors reserve and redeem their visits here. It includes email marketing, and, volunteer management. So it's really a lot more vast than the original sort of scope of it, which had to do with a software platform. Having to do mostly with image and rich media files used across the institution, but that sort of provided the framework for other types of situ… other types of platforms that encompass the same sort of wide remit.

[00:21:13] Joy Pagdilao: Yeah, I… when Jean was explaining this to me, she described it as a lot of the different aspects of the Huntington were siloed before, and then through your…would you call it, like, division, or your… your team? You guys were able to basically integrate, like, a lot more of those aspects and… and, the systems that y'all use.

[00:21:36] Yvonne Lee: Yes, yeah, that's absolutely accurate. I would say that, within a department, usually, there's at least one, if not many, software applications that are being used for a particular purpose that is specific and tailor-made to that department's, goals. But, because there are so many different departments here at the Huntington, and we work with by and large overlapping segments of our audiences, whether they are our long-term, short-term fellows, the readers who come and use our collections on a daily basis, our visitors who come to enjoy the gardens, children and families that come to enjoy, the programming here, botanists, scientists, etc. We're all sort of dealing with the same large pool of folks that are sometimes external, but not always. Oftentimes, there is sort of a porousness, where sometimes they become internal in the form of fellows working with, here, or interns, or consultants, and so…all of the data have some sort of…value information, something that can help us make decisions better for providing them with the services that they come to the Huntington for, and it is important that we understand the context of where the data are coming from and, whether or not it's something that should play a role in this key decision-making point or not.

[00:23:38] Joy Pagdilao: Okay, thank you so much. That really helps me to, like, also understand, your position, yeah. I just thought it's so cool. It sounds like, to me, it feels like it falls under access, then.

Yvonne Lee: Interesting, yeah. It could be. There is a lot of questions of access about, especially with personally identifiable information. Confidentiality, privacy, security, the right to be forgotten, etc. And so, definitely access, and the counterpart to that, which is privacy, confidentiality, and security.

[00:24:27] Joy Pagdilao: Okay. Wow, yeah. That makes sense, too, when you're talking about the porousness of, like, all these different visitors. Yeah, so cool! Okay. I think…what I want to tackle next is… you talked about the classes that you took here in the program, and…like… aspects of, I guess, your education that helped with, I guess, preparation for this position. Yeah, I guess, like, we can take…that question next. So, yeah, you talked about classes that were geared towards informatics and databases. Do you want to maybe talk about, some of the applications, or some of the, like, softwares that, helped you prepare for this role? Yeah, like, maybe, like, trainings, or…I know another question that we have is, are there any associations that you were, like, provided help from, or… yeah.

[00:25:33] Yvonne Lee: Sure, yeah. So, Jonathan Ferner's class on digital asset management was very helpful, in that we had the opportunity to actually work with a product itself and get an understanding of, and so even though it wasn't a class specifically on databases per se, through going through the motions of a DAMS manager, you got the opportunity to actually use different systems and sort of understand their limitations and the types of things that, would facilitate a more robust use of that versus a more restricted or more narrow sort of application of that tool within an organization.

And, I believe Linda Tadich is now teaching that class, and I'm sure she, probably, also has something in that her… the students who take that are able to try on different, sort of, DAMS products, just to get an understanding of the now…three generations of DAMS products that are available on the market, and understand the sort of strengths and weaknesses of them, compared to the type of business context that you want to use them towards.

So…definitely anything that has to do with… oh, there was also an open… so this is prior to the Carpentries being at UCLA, but I did end up taking a carpentries class, a data carpentries class, that was being offered at Caltech, and so, that was really cool, and got a chance to work with OpenRefine and Python in refining… scraping and refining data off of the web. And that was a really fantastic class to just get an understanding of how to manipulate data on a larger scale, data that's not controlled by you, that's not carefully entered in through these cataloging rules that you said that people are adhering to, that these policies are being enforced, but anything and everything that you might be getting from

the web, and how it is that you would go through the, motions of cleaning that to make it just information to something that's actually, useful, right? So, that was incredibly helpful.

Chris Borgman's, data management class, had… several of her courses actually, had us working with different organizations to work on a data management policy, and so, that was really helpful to understand how granting organizations like the NEH or the NEA have a data management policy that's now part of their application, and that's something that is…especially back then when it was relatively new, sort of an afterthought, and working with organizations to understand sort of the very complex needs, where oftentimes it's not just the data in a spreadsheet that you hand over to a repository, but you have to take whole snapshots of the, of the computer itself to understand what programs and contingencies are required in order for that data to run properly in the case of, like geospatial information data, or, yeah, so, that was really fantastic, and working with different organizations, like, Harvard's Dataverse to understand what is the sort of contract for, placing your data there as a repository, and making that accessible for other researchers as well. That was incredibly helpful to have that sort of hands-on, real-world experience.

[00:29:10] Joy Pagdilao: It sounds like you got… Personally. I feel like you got, like, a more comprehensive, hands-on…like, program experience than I'm having right now. Oh, I'm sorry, I'm sorry. It's okay. I will say, I'm taking, like, I'm actually taking… I think all of my classes this quarter are with Jean.

We're taking a class on cataloging, and again, like, I've never really worked with… I guess I consider cataloging, like, backend, because it's concerning, like, cataloging and, like, all these standards and, like, all this different metadata. It's been some really interesting stuff. And I say this because, like, that's, like, I think that, and then we took a children's literature… no, children's programs and services class last quarter. Both of those were so hands-on and, like, really… I think, me personally, it helped me…get, like, such a better sense of, like, what the industry looks like and what it feels like to really step into the shoes of someone who's a professional in this field and to, like, apply themselves, like, using all these different, like, tools to really understand the work. I… Yeah. Yeah.

[00:30:24] Yvonne Lee: I think maybe if I might make a suggestion, like, one interesting thing that may help bridge the gap between, sort of, like, the presentation layer, or working more closely with audiences, rather than working more on the, sort of back-end systems, data entry and whatnot might be, to look into search, right? So, for part of my position, it's also understanding human-commuter interactions.

So the Huntington recently launched an online collections discovery portal. So if you go to “huntington.org/collections”, we are bringing together, for the first time, our library art and botanical collections together in one unified portal experience, whereas before, you would have to go to the library catalog specifically, you would have to go to the art museum's eMuseum instance, and then for botanical, you would have to go to the ESRI map in order to see the plants that are publicly available. It brings it all together into one unified portal, and for that, it's really difficult, to try to first standardize and normalize all of those very diversely different types of collections records, and then, of course, make them accessible via search and discovery.

So, the way that we, worked with our vendors to come up with an elasticsearch, sort of formula that would hopefully yield the results that most of our audiences would expect. So if they type in “rose”, just by sheer number of collection items, you're more likely to get a library collection record than you are a plant record, which is odd, because most people would assume if I type in "rose”, likely to get a picture of a rose and some information about the various roses that are at a part of the Huntington's Living [Collections] and, and so we had to work on tweaking, and it really required a very, strong understanding of the data and the data across all of the divisions, and so this is, again, where the sort of pan-institutional integrated systems really came into play, is not just being… we brought together experts and data stewards within each of the divisions, but also having an understanding across all three of them was vital to be able to provide better, an improved experience. It's definitely not perfect. You're still much more likely to get a library poem about a rose. But you will get a search result for a, living specimen of a rose within the first 2 or 3 rows of your search results now, as a result of, yeah, the way that we had tweaked, search.

[00:33:21] Joy Pagdilao: Yeah, that's so cool, yeah. I would assume that… because I've heard of the Huntington, like, as I've been growing up, like, I've heard about it in high school, and, like, my friends have visited, throughout, like, college, undergrad. And I… I, for one, didn't even know that there was, like, an integration and, like, a whole, like, reorganizing of all of the different structures. So, yeah, like, as a user, I would have assumed that if I searched something up, then it would have given me results from, like, everywhere else as well, but…

Yeah, I guess…maybe that's just something that I have to implement into my own, like, applications and, like, reflections, but, like, thinking about being a user and, like, the person

who's, like, asking for services, which I definitely did a lot more of last quarter when I was doing a lot more hands-on work. A lot of this quarter, I think, is a lot of theoretical stuff. Yeah.

[00:34:21] Yvonne Lee: Yeah, and I remember when I was looking at, you know, graduate programs that were ALA accredited, that was one of the criticisms that I regularly encountered about the UCLA program in particular, was that it didn't offer a lot of hands-on, sort of real-world, opportunities in the way that San Jose State would. And yet, I was still able to find those courses that did allow working with real, clients, right, as a consultant, and… and working with real products and platforms and things. So, yeah.

[00:34:58] Joy Pagdilao: Yeah. I'm just, yeah, I'm definitely, like, as a first year, I'm still, like, working my way around and trying to figure out exactly where to, like, throw my hands in so that I can get that work. And I'm starting to, like, like, things are, things are lining up. Things are looking up.

[00:35:14] Yvonne Lee: I also did things, I realized, somewhat backwards, in that for the first year, I really wanted to prioritize more specific class, like, more, specific informatics and, archival courses. And I wanted to leave the more general foundational courses for my second year. A, because they were easy to schedule, and I knew that they would be available, whereas the more specialized cohort courses may not be necessarily, but, also, I just wanted to get into, like, I was really impatient, so I really wanted to get into knowing sort of these things, which maybe I wouldn't recommend, but is the way that I did it, and so perhaps that also sort of affected the way that I understood when I did get to the foundational courses.

[00:35:59] Joy Pagdilao: I… I'll tell you after this, but, like, I definitely have plans of, like, the way that I'm scheduling, or hopefully, like, scheduling classes for next quarter, or next quarter, next year. Yeah. Yeah, because I don't want to… I need to… I need to get this interview done!

I… the next question I did want to tackle was, what does, like, a typical day-to-day for you look like? Or, like, is there a typical day-to-day? Like, what are some of… If there isn't a typical day-to-day, I guess I've asked this for other professionals, like, how would you break down, in percentages, what your work would look like?

[00:36:39] Yvonne Lee: Sure, so, there are two major buckets, audiences and collections, that are part of the integrated systems that my department, is responsible for supporting in

some way. And so, generally speaking, one of the section that might be meeting with users to hear about pain points and or feature enhancements that could make their work better, easier, faster, less hand-wrought and more automated. So, it's meeting with actual users, it's, facilitating meetings, larger meetings with, sort of administrators or power users to hear their thoughts and give them information.

So, a lot of the enterprise applications go through a regular sort of software schedule of two upgrades a year. One is generally more of a patch, the other one is a major upgrade, and so for each of these, we meet together and we go through all of the changes that are coming. We decide what we want to test and not test. And then we usually write a testing script so that when the actual upgrade is available and test, we know in advance what to expect and what to tell our users to expect if there are any changes to their workflow, or if there'll be any major disruptions to their workflow, we'll go ahead and flag those early on for the software developers further, to fix. And then, the day of implementation, the day of upgrade, in production, then we'll go, of course, be on call for any kind of support for any unintended, bugs or glitches that may occur. It's working with vendors, and so I meet fairly regularly with the vendors that we have already contracted with, as well as meeting with new potential vendors.

There's always something new, out there in the world of technology, there's always a new service that's promising to do it better, faster, cheaper. And so, I would say that a small portion of my time is also spent just taking calls with vendors to hear about what their products are doing, and to hear… and to assess whether or not that makes sense for the Huntington, or is perhaps too experimental, or we don't have a use case just yet, but it's good to have in the back pocket if we should ever need you know, a much more robust digital preservation plan, for example. So, that's a component of it as well.

A lot of it is hearing, being in meetings, internal meetings, to hear about upcoming, programs and initiatives and projects, and trying to understand how systems may support these, data may support these. And, it's a lot of communication, I would say, a lot of reporting up and out. We are a service department so, and a strategic department at the same time, and so we are hoping to help consult and be brought on early, but if that's not the case, then, we sort of have to speed up a little bit to sort of understand what's the situation right now, and how best can we support it as it is now, if we're not able to be part of the project at the beginning? What can we do, sort of, halfway or at the end of a project to help support, whatever the needs of that project are.

[00:40:24] Joy Pagdilao: I like how you described it as service and strategic department. Mhm.

[00:40:29] Yvonne Lee: Yeah, so if someone's like, oh, I have this need, then, you know of course, we'll find a solution for it, you know, but oftentimes, if it's something larger, like, say, an AI policy for the organization, we're a little bit, ahead of that, and so we can be strategic and consult on, well, here's what we know, and this sort of gets to, I think, the question that's also in the document about invisible labor. I don't know if I would consider it invisible in that my understanding of invisible labor is that oftentimes it's sort of undervalued, and so this might just fit into work that may not necessarily be done within the hours of 9 to 5. But keeping an eye on, technology news, it affects all of us, the ways that information is being used against people, being very mindful about issues in security and privacy, right? Once you start amassing these large data sets and they are integrated, that is, of course, a huge concern, and so… being really mindful about not only best practices, but promising practices, emerging practices in the field to try to safeguard, privacy.

[00:41:44] Joy Pagdilao: Okay, yeah, okay, yeah. Oh my gosh, I had another question that I was, like, lined up for, and then…Oh, yes. So, I guess we talked about, like, hard skills, so, like, what, were some of the skills that you learned during the program that really helped with preparing you for this role, technically. And within that, like, strategic aspect of it, were there any particular… positions, classes, group assignments, anything that, like, helped you with that communication aspect of it? Or, like, that got you used to, I guess talking to clients, and, like, that, like. yeah, person-to-person kind of interaction, or would you say that was more of, like, your former profession that kind of kicked in in that experience?

[00:42:42] Yvonne Lee: I don't doubt that there were definitely courses, especially the foundational courses, the core classes, that spoke to, communications within a workplace, but because I had come to my MLIS program after working, for… let's see, graduated… Starting 28, so 5 years? 5 or 6 years, working, I think that I drew probably more on my experiences as a working professional, rather than… and, it was just supplemented by the information or the types of exercises in the core classes. Yeah, just because there were so many different types of learning how to communicate with Hmm… collections managers, and art advisors, and… finance folks, and artists themselves, and, estates, legal entities that are preserving, the…the intellectual property of artists, so I probably drew more upon that. Honestly, in this role and in subsequent roles after having graduated from the MLIS program, than primarily drawing upon information from coursework.

[00:44:08] Joy Pagdilao: That sounds good. Okay, do you think your position, with integrated systems is something that is, like, growing as, like, a job trend? Yeah, I'm looking at the job market outlook and labor trends, like, area. Is your field growing, shrinking? Are parts of it expanding while others contract? And, yeah, have you… did you always see yourself working in… Like, this aspect of integration… And, yeah, like, this “bridging” [work]?

[00:44:47] Yvonne Lee: Ah. So, I should take a step back and say that my title is made up.

[00:44:55] Joy Pagdilao: Yes, yes. Jean also made that very clear.

[00:45:00] Yvonne Lee: And so, I think… for me. I'm only aware of my own sort of path of how it is that I got here.

When I graduated from the MLIS program, I was, frankly, frustrated by the lack of roles that I saw that really spoke to my interests and my abilities, of all of the different ways that I think that I can contribute to cultural heritage work.
And so, I took things that were maybe… I applied for roles that were maybe anywhere from 40% to 60-70% of what I had sort of determined as being the thing that I would like to do, and if it's helpful, I… find myself going back to this exercise where I write out what I want to do a professional, how it is that I would like to contribute, and I always update that document, because it changes over time. And it has less to do, honestly, with day-to-day tasks. And with different tools that I'm using, and more to do with goals of what, what is the impact that I want to see in a workplace based on the efforts that I've made at this workplace?
And… and I'm pretty agnostic when it comes to how it is. And so, if it's learning a new program, I will learn a new program. If it's learning a new skill, then I'll figure it out. But it has more to do with, sort of, what it is that I would like, what I intend, what I would like to be able to provide, and less to do with the alignment of roles as they're written out in job description posts.

Non-profit work has been very open to that, I think. My experience in the for-profit sector has been that it is a lot more… it is less porous, it is a lot more sort of hard-lined in terms of these are the sort of business units, and the work of each business unit, and the carefully scoped out responsibilities of each role, whereas with nonprofits, you know, there is the joke that, you wear a lot of hats, right? And, and so, but in that way, I have… Found it both… Overwhelming at times, but also really, wonderfully exploratory, like, there's a lot of, leeway given to see, like, well, here's a smaller project, let's see how you do with this.

And that's grown and grown and grown with each successful sort of project and each lesson learned. And then building a need for a role like integrated systems has come largely out of, well, what if I were to help you with this? Okay, well then what if we were to take that to the next logical step and also help with this? And then taking on more and more, and sort of that's how my particular career path has grown, and so it's hard to say, given that it is a very DIY, sort of organic, and very, individual sort of pathway to know sector-wide how that would translate to roles of this type, because it's a hybrid that's borrowed across many different things that in other for-profit or more, rigidly structured organizations would be so vastly different. So I don't know that I can give a really good answer to that, unfortunately!

[00:48:55] Joy Pagdilao: It's okay. Okay. No, no, yeah. I, I, I just love, like. I think we just wanna hear… your perspective on what your role is. And, yeah, because you do have… Such, like, a unique role. It was all really cool for us to learn about, basically, when, like, Jean was, like, talking about, like, the interview, and, like, us prep… like, her prepping… per prepping us for our talk.

But yes, okay. We've talked about skills, we've talked about your schooling. Oh, yeah, any special organizations that you're a part of, professional organizations, conferences that you attend, journals that you interact with? I say “interact with” because, you talked about different researchers that do attend, like, the Huntington… Yeah, I guess maybe, like, more aspects of, like, what data and, like, places do you interact with?

[00:50:03] Yvonne Lee: Yeah, ASIST (Association for Information Science and Technology)? Digital Library, Forum (DLF). AMIA?...VRA (Visual Resources Association), they have a lot of fantastic resources available for people who are interested in digital asset management in the library and museum sense. Also in the corporate- in the for-profit private sector sense as well, there are a number of, for-profit professional organizations also, like the Henry Stewart DAMs. And they often have a DAM LA, convening, which is really expensive, frankly, to attend the conference, but they do have, oftentimes, a free glam… DAM in GLAM web conference, and… may be really beneficial, to hear from practitioners in the field, specifically in cultural heritage institutions. There is museumsandtheweb[.com]. They produce fantastic scholarly journal articles that I continue to go back to, even though they are 10 plus years old, just hear sort of how wise people are. And then the Museum Computer Network is a conference that meets once a year of museum technologists. it's always a lot of fun. This year, they're gonna be in Seattle, and I always find that that's a fantastic networking opportunity, a way to learn about all of the different ways that digital technology and data are,

can translate to positions and roles in museums and libraries. And that one's really cool. Let's see… the Journal of Digital Media Management (JDMM). Again, expensive, but of course, if you find an article, or if you have access to an article database, or you can always email the authors and ask them for a free copy of their article, and they're of course always happy to send that off to you. That's been really beneficial.

And then, I usually end up subscribing to a number of Substacks, and different newsletters, right? Listsservs and things. And so, again, MCN has a listserv that's very active, that's fantastic. Stowe Boyd has a workplace sort of psychology, I guess, Substack, which is really fantastic.

There is the Museum Human, written by, a colleague over at The MET. And that's really fantastic as well. If you're interested in, sort of, pedagogy and museum education, as it also intersects a lot with data and, digital, particularly- Oh my goodness, there's a Kyle Bowen's blog and newsletter, which is very active. Yeah, there are a lot of resources that are available, and, no shortage of ways to sort of find folks who are doing these sort of interesting things, and oftentimes, again, speaking to maybe nonprofits, or the sort of interrelated… areas of knowledge of the work itself. People who are technologists, but also anti-technologists, or people who are museum folks who have also worked in the private sector for a long time. There are a lot of these sort of folks that are… interested in what they're interested as, and follow that through no matter where the roles are. So it also helps to give a sense of, wow, it's interesting that that's a role that somebody has created in this field. I would have never looked for a job with that particular title, but having somebody sort of explain it out makes me think that maybe this might be, an interesting fit, you know, for now.

[00:54:37] Joy Pagdilao: Okay. I have 2 minutes. For the last question, I think what I want to end off with that I think will wrap things pretty well and give, like, a good overview is…If you were to prepare…the next person to take on your role, what are some of the things that you would tell them about? Like, hard/soft skills, like, that they should prepare for? What kind of, like, I guess, like, [is] the mindset that you want to take on? Any, like, particular aspects, tips, tricks? Like, what would… what's, like, I guess, like, the knowledge that you would want to…make sure that, like, they have?… Yeah.

[00:55:22] Yvonne Lee: Most things aren't technology problems, they're people problems. But you have to help support them through technology, digital, and data, because that is the remit of the role.

Oftentimes we were trying to solve for something that, frankly, may be better handled through direct communication, but for whatever reason, that may not always be possible, and to…listen to all user complaints. There's always a gem. There's always something important there that someone is trying to communicate to you that will help you in this role.

[00:56:09] Joy Pagdilao: People, yeah. I fully agree. I think one thing that I really appreciate is…like, this program has taught me that, like, being as accessible as possible and doing as good of a job as you possibly can to provide as quality of a service as you can to help the public. I think that's where, like, my heart lies, like… Through everything, yeah. But yeah, I think… I don't want to hold you, so…

Yeah, I think… I think we're good to go. And then let me just stop recording.